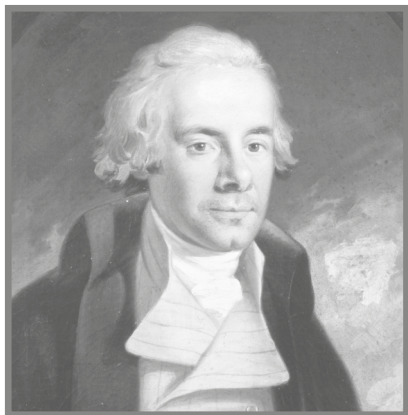




William Wilberforce, portrayed here by Karl Anton Hickel, was a fervent Christian and the British politician who campaigned most vociferously against the slave trade.

enslaved person was free once on British soil—but Britons prided themselves on their defense of fundamental freedoms.

Even so, Britain was also, by some margin, the West's leading slave-trading nation. It was this contradiction that offended both religious and Enlightenment political sensibilities alike.

Global changes

To a number of high-minded and unusually active campaigners such as William Wilberforce and Thomas Clarkson, the abolition of slavery became an imperative. A remarkably effective campaign was

launched that, despite entrenched opposition, rapidly won wide public and parliamentary support. For much of the 19th century, the Royal Navy would be at the forefront of the campaign to intercept those still engaged in slave trading.

While Britain took the lead, the movement had important supporters elsewhere. The revolutionary French National Convention outlawed slavery in 1794 (though this would partially be overturned by Napoleon in 1802). Brazil aside, where slavery would not be banned until 1888, all the newly independent states that emerged in Latin America after 1810 likewise outlawed slavery.

It wasn't until 1833 that slavery itself, as opposed to the trade, was made illegal in the British Empire. Whatever the efforts of a new set of campaigners, not least Elizabeth Heyrick, the motive was not entirely humanitarian. The Haitian slave revolt, which began in 1791 and led to the emergence of an independent Haiti in 1804, had left the West uncomfortably aware that any such uprisings might prove difficult to suppress. A slave revolt in British-ruled Jamaica in 1831 reinforced the point: in the longer term, freeing the enslaved might prove less trouble than enslaving them.

The United States, forward-looking and expansive, remained the great troubling sore. The more abolitionists in its industrializing northern states denounced slavery, the more its southern states, their agrarian economies dependent on enslaved labor, were determined to retain it. It would take a four-year civil war and 670,000 dead to settle the question. ■

The Haitian Revolt

Few uprisings illustrate the contradictions of the revolutions that swept across the late 18th-century Western world better than that in Haiti (1791–1804). This French Caribbean colony, known as St. Domingue, owed its enormous prosperity to enslaved labor. The revolt, led by a formerly enslaved man, Toussaint

L'Ouverture, was inspired by the American and French revolutions. Yet neither country supported it: The US was concerned it might inspire similar revolts in its slave states; France, despite its pledge to abolish slavery, was wary of the damage to its trade. Spain, which ruled the eastern half of the island, also opposed it, as did Britain, fearing it would spread to its own

colonies. Even the South American colonies seeking independence refused to back it, fearful of its impact among their substantial enslaved populations. Yet the occasional combined resources of all these states were unable to quell the uprising. This was the only slave revolt to result in the emergence of an independent state.